

Claude Shannon at MIT. Shannon was a joint professor of mathematics and engineering, and one of only two Distinguished Professors at MIT. I went to his secretary and asked if I could get an appointment. She said, “He might see you for five minutes, but he doesn’t talk to people if he is not interested. So don’t expect more than a very brief interview.”

Did you know anything about his reputation when you went to see him?²

No, I didn’t know anything other than that he was a member of the National Academy of Sciences and a distinguished professor at MIT.

I went over to Shannon’s office on a gloomy winter afternoon, just after lunch, and found this elfish-looking man, about 5’7”, salt-and-pepper hair, very trim, with a twinkle in his eye and very ready intelligence. I told him what it was I wanted. He read my abstract and said, “Well, instead of calling it ‘A Winning Strategy for Blackjack,’ we better call it ‘A Favorable Strategy for Twenty One,’ which sounds a little more academic and dignified.” He cross-examined me for about 10 or 15 minutes and said, “It looks like you have found all the really big ideas here.” He indicated that we needed to condense the paper, which is why many of the discoveries that were in my book were not in the paper; they were edited out for size. Then Shannon asked, “What else are you working on?”

At this point, I need to go back to 1955 and pick up the roulette story. I had just gotten my master’s in physics, and I was sitting in the dining room of the University Cooperative Housing Association (UCHA), an independent low-cost student living group near the UCLA campus, where I resided. People would gather there to take study breaks and to argue about everything. Someone brought up roulette and was explaining why you couldn’t possibly win. I said, “I don’t think that is true.” I made my case. Some of the people were interested in working on it. I started a little group, which faded away fairly rapidly, but I pursued it on my own.

A fellow I was tutoring bought me a half-size roulette wheel in appreciation for my help—he knew I wanted one—and I bought a stopwatch that ticked in hundredths of a second, which was a fairly large expenditure for me. I did field experiments, setting up a movie camera on